Books

In my formative years I purchased books that greatly influenced my interpretation of the requirements to be successful in woodturning. Many of these books were purchased long before the notion of becoming a full-time turner raised its head.

Interestingly books on design featured almost equally alongside those on turning instruction, right from the start. I have always been drawn to well-designed work in whatever medium. Most crafts can usually be learnt if you have good hand-eye co-ordination and are willing to put in the many hours required. With turning, long hours at the lathe often performing repetitive cuts to nail the technique, will build an understanding of how the tools work best, building confidence and proficiency. Technique is a means to an end, freeing your creativity. Ernie Conover's words have great resonance: "Good craft is necessary to create good art and the best craft without art will still be ugly in the morning. You have to have craft, mastering the medium to produce art."

To underline the above, Frank Pain's 1958 book *The Practical Woodturner* shows that his instructions mean just what they say: "Tools do what you want them to do when you know what they want to do… My aim is to show you how to cut wood as it prefers to be cut." These are wonderful statements; this book was my bible from which I learnt to turn correctly and proficiently.

Gerald James' 1958 book *Woodturning Design and Practice* opens with these words: "Some people will say I am putting the cart before the horse. To talk about design before describing the lathe and turning methods… but I feel very strongly that it is an essential prelude to making any piece…"

Ronald Seal's 1964 publication *Practical Designs for Woodturning* underscores this view with many more telling comments: "It is no more difficult to make an article of good design than one which is bad or indifferent."

SH Glenister's photographic book *Contemporary Design in Woodwork: v. 3* in 1968 gave a good overview of what was happening in the wood world at that time.

Other turning books in those early years were *Woodturning* by Geoff Peters in 1961, Peter Child's *The Craftsman Woodturner* in 1971 and Gordon Stokes' three publications of the 1970s (*Beginner's Guide to Woodturning*, *Modern Wood Turning* and *The Manual of Woodturning*). It was Pain and Peters that made a lasting impression on me, along with James and Seale. Professor David Pye's 1968 publication *The Nature and Art of Workmanship* is not a turners' book, although he was both a turner and carver; to my mind this book remains required reading for any self-respecting craftsman. Dale Nish published *Creative Woodturning* in 1975, followed by *Artistic Woodturning* in 1980. These two books changed forever the format of turning books; several writers and publishers copied their style.

CHANGES IN 50 YEARS

- Turners' hardware: tools, chucks, lathes, etc. are all light years beyond what was available 50 years ago
- Information: a willingness to share knowledge through international seminars, national organisations, woodturning clubs, wood shows, courses, instructional videos, DVDs, on the internet via YouTube, for example. Many of these are relatively new phenomena
- Publishing: this is almost unrecognisable, including instructional and coffee table books, dedicated turning magazines and online publishing
- Purchasing: most of the woodturners' needs are supplied by mail order. This even covers wood; I don't get that, you really need to see wood in the flesh, to handle and examine it, unless you have extreme trust in the person who is supplying it
- Marketing: this is an area where change has also being dramatic. Craft shops, galleries, fairs and exhibitions still play a big part in selling your products. The internet has again kicked in here with many makers selling much of their work through websites. I can see the attraction for craft items like wooden fruit, letter openers, paper weights, etc. However, high-priced, ticketed art work items leave me somewhat baffled; personally I would feel the need to handle and see them in the flesh, making a proper informed judgement
- Collectors and museums: I link these two headings together as they often go hand in hand. A number of collectors have donated collections to various museums and through this, other museums have taken notice. Today, many institutions who would never have given turned wood a second look, now have pieces in their collections. For the most part the majority of these pieces are classed as art; another phenomenon of more recent years

Early 1970s teak egg cups by Ray Key, found in an Oxfam shop in 2010 priced at £1.49

Makers of influence

The following makers had a huge influence on me in the 1960s and early 1970s: Dennis French, John Trippas, Tim Green, George Snead, Douglas Hart and David Pye. Most were producing quality domestic woodware. I decided that you needed to aspire to their standards if you wanted to make a career in turning. Gloucestershire-based Dennis French is still turning; he tells me his range is bigger than ever at the age of 83. John Trippas was down in Devon making a fine range of domestic products, as was Tim Green in Oxfordshire, trading as Crowdy Wood Products. Both Trippas and Green also made furniture and employed staff.

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